



Alexa skills to accept payments

Skills for Amazon's Alexa will soon be able to accept Amazon Pay and make purchases directly within voice apps. <http://digit.in/AlexaPay>



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intended to follow (inductive charging) the parts required were either too big, too expensive or both, to be viable for end users. It took almost a decade for that technology to reach approachable standards.



Current generation Qi chargers for smartphones have taken ergonomics into account

Towards the end of that decade, the Wireless Power Consortium was setup by a bunch of companies to promote the Qi standard (pronounced Chi) - based on inductive resonant coupling. This standard still wasn't truly wireless, since, in addition to it requiring a charging base to be wired into a socket, it also required the device to be within 5 mm of the charging base. Although, that limit was overcome soon and the specification was extended to medium power supply (upto 120 W). While it is widely believed that in 2011, Samsung became the first company to bring out a wireless charging pad for the Droid Charge (SCH-i510), it was actually the Palm Pre in 2009. Armed with a wireless charging compatible back and an inductive charger dubbed Touchstone, it would be the first commercially available wireless charging solution.

Although LG and Nokia had beaten Samsung to inbuilt wireless charging support with the LG Optimus LTE2 on one side and the Lumia 820 and 920 on another,

it wasn't to stay that way for long. Samsung eventually took the lead with the Galaxy range of devices, with the Galaxy S6 onwards supporting inbuilt wireless charging. Additionally, Samsung also refined the ergonomics of the wireless charging setup by supporting a vertical charging arrangement, something that would significantly improve the usability.

WATTUP

While one part of the tech industry might be busy patting itself on the back for bringing wireless charging via inductive charging, another part has been busy bringing about true wireless charging - something that can power devices across a room, or even farther.

If you've been keeping track of CES extensively over the last few years, you might have noticed a company named Energous touting true wireless charging technology for quite a while. Founded in 2013, the company has been demoing WattUp, radio frequency (RF) based charging solution that delivers power via radio bands, similar to a Wi-Fi router. The idea of using radio frequencies for transmitting power isn't new. In fact, some of the earliest public demonstrations of wireless power transfer using radio waves date as far back as 1964.



The idea behind WattUp is to power all your devices at the same time, cord-free

What Energous did claim to do was increase the efficiency. While they have claimed that they aim to bring out successful wireless charging solutions the work even at a distance of 15 feet, their current offerings work at a few inches. They have explained that their focus was redirected towards miniaturisation - which they have achieved, with Sticker-like receivers the size of a paper clip. While medium range power transfer is supposed to be released soon, the actual 15-foot long range transfer should release early next year according to the company.

FUTURE

As mentioned earlier, what we refer to as 'wireless charging' today isn't



Similar chargers all along roadways would, in theory, provide unlimited fuel to electric automobiles

true wireless. That doesn't mean it is going away anytime soon. Inductive charging provides a level of efficiency and reliability that other solutions, including RF-based ideas haven't been able to demonstrate yet. For critical applications such as appliances or electric vehicles, inductive charging will remain the way to go.

Using radio frequencies for power transfer is gaining traction and is mostly likely to be realised in home environments. Much like the connected homes of today, technologies like WattUp from Energous are going to make your home a wire-free zone from a power point of view as well - but they're unlikely to make much difference anywhere else in our day to day lives any time soon. 